

Challenges and Support Strategies in Online Piano Learning: A Content Analysis of Online Discussion Forums

Liujin Chen

PhD Student, School of Music
College of Design, Art & Performance



Introduction

1 Now

- The COVID pandemic pushed music learning online.
- Many now learn piano via apps, video courses, YouTube, and live online lessons.

2 What research has looked at

- One-to-one lessons by video call (Martínez Hernández, 2020)
- Teacher behavior in distance piano lessons (Comeau et al., 2019)
- Music teachers' online communities (Gee, 2026)
- Adult learners' views through interviews (Roulston et al., 2015)

3 Less visible

- Learners who study on their own, with apps and videos
- Learners' own words, not answers to researchers' questions
- How the community responds to each difficulty

4 Why forums

- Learners post on their own initiative, unprompted.
- Questions and replies appear side by side.
- Large amount of text: can a LLM help screen the data?

Purpose

- To identify and categorize the common challenges and needs of online piano learners and describe the support strategies offered by the community.

Research Questions

- What difficulties do online piano learners report?
- What strategies and support does the community offer?
- Which strategies correspond to which difficulties?
- To what extent do a researcher and a LLM agree in screening the data using the same criteria?

Procedures

1 Collect Data

1,170 posts

Reddit 1,058 Piano Tell 91
PianoWorld 21
Public, self-initiated posts

2 Screening

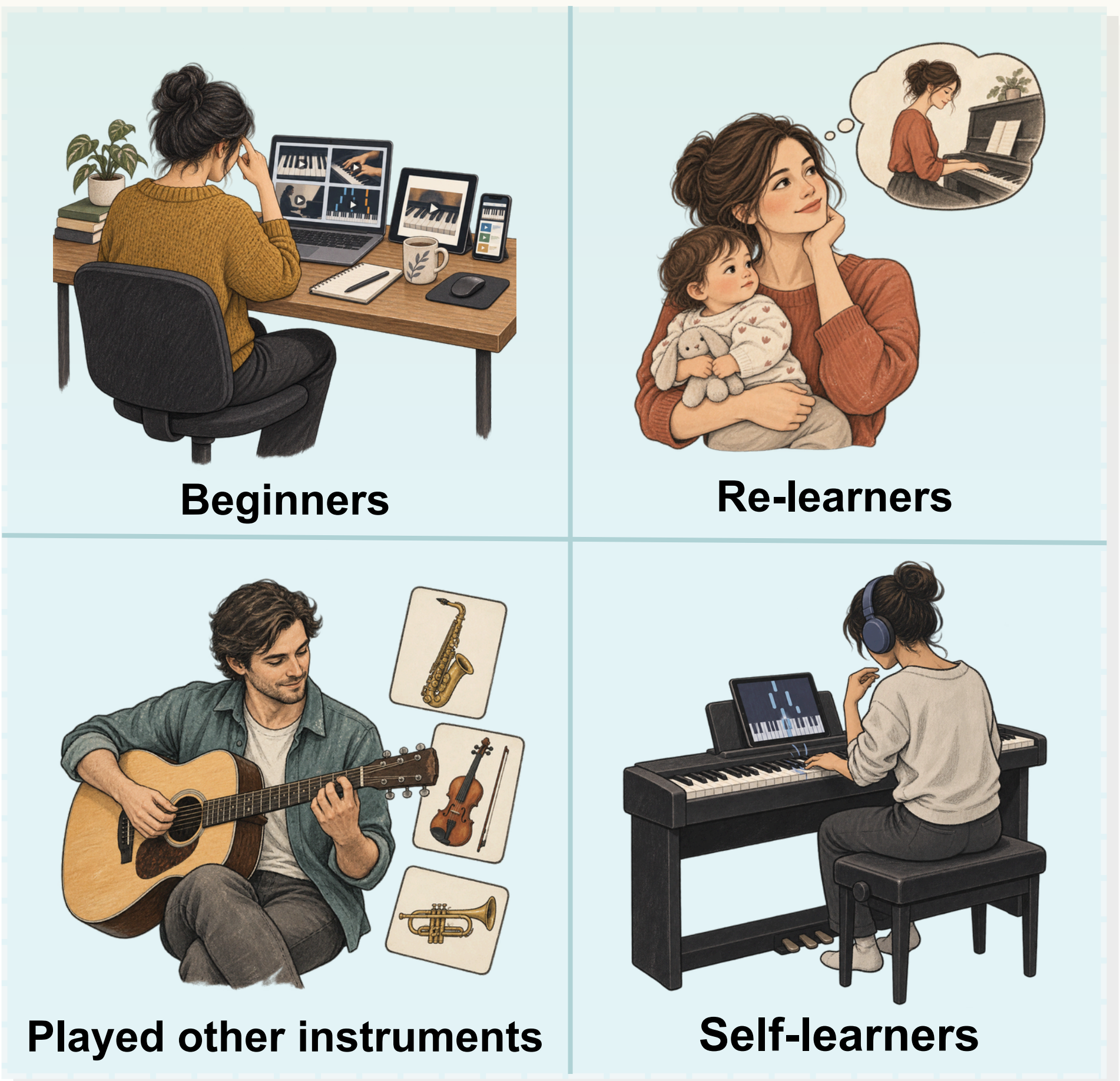
721 included

1,122 after the date limit
and de-duplication
Researcher + LLM $k=.81$

3 Coding

72 posts 498 replies

10% systematic subsample
open coding
95 post codes; 79 reply codes

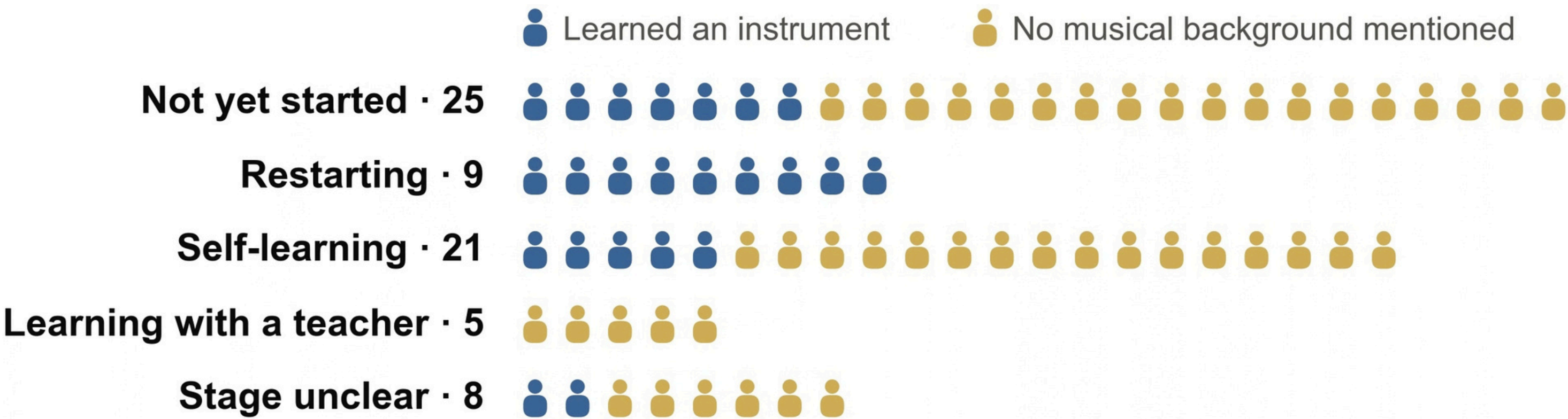


Who were initiating the postings?

Who were giving responses?

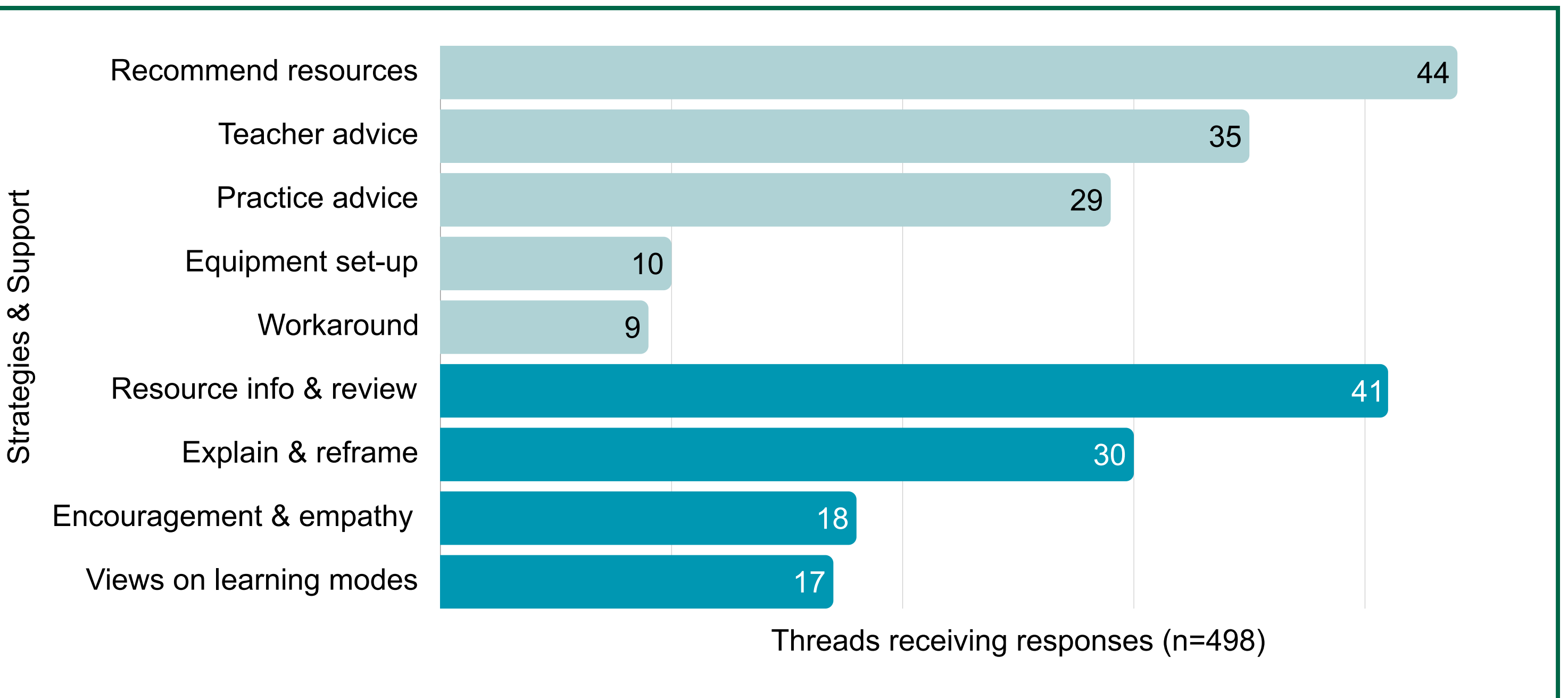
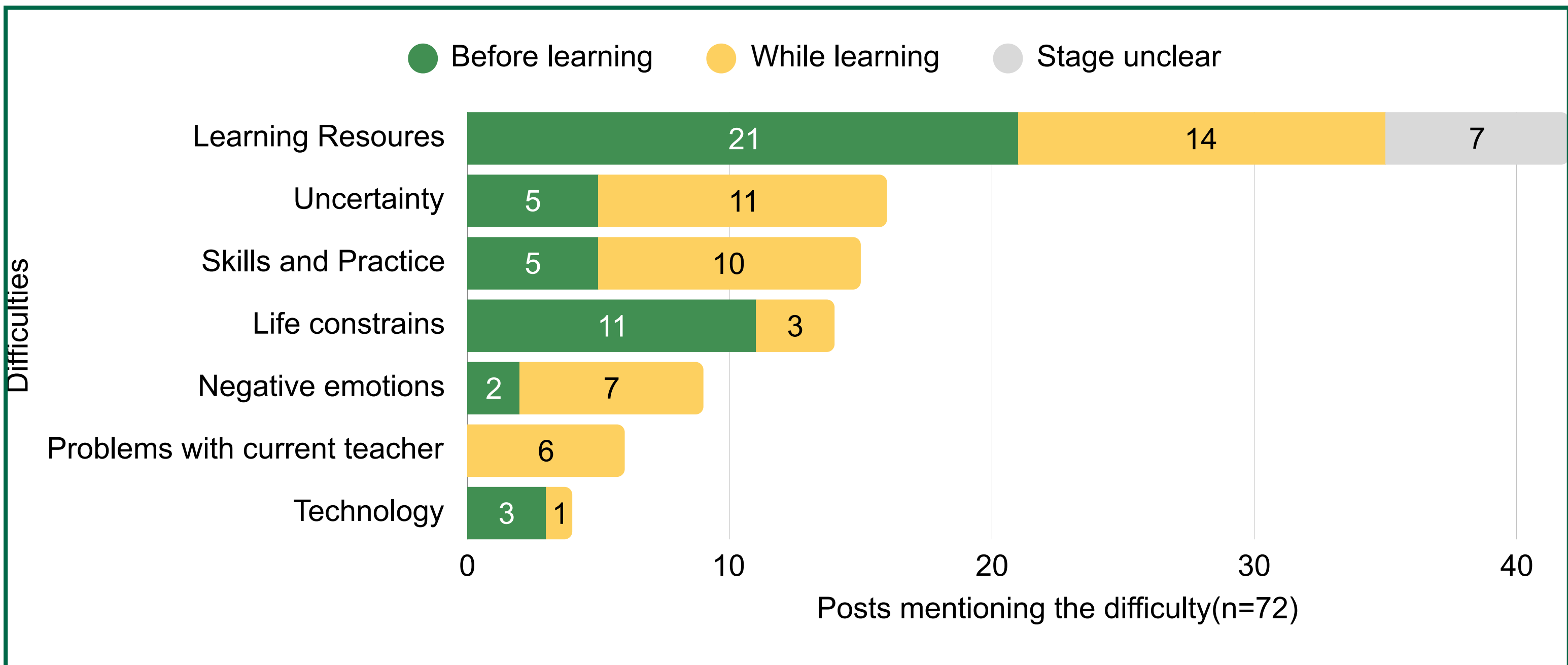
- Fellow learners: from beginners a few weeks in to long-time hobbyists.
- Teachers: often citing their years of teaching.
- Commercial promoters: own courses, channels, or "DM me"; some were teachers.

Learners Profile



Each figure = one post (n = 68; 4 posts written for a child or an older relative are not shown).
Each row shows a different stage of learning piano. Colour shows whether the post mentioned having learned any instrument before this piano learning (including piano earlier in life); all restarting learners had. No post mentioned a musical background without an instrument (e.g., only singing or theory). Only 3 of the 45 yellow posts said outright that the learner had none.

Results



Themes

1. Competing options, missing criteria

Learners faced many competing courses, apps, and videos, but had no clear way to decide on them. Independent reviews were scarce, so they asked peers for first-hand experience.

2. Online lesson as fallback

About a quarter of the learners treated online lessons as a second choice. Replies seldom argued that online was better; they said it was not ideal, but good enough to start.

3. Rebuilding seeing and hearing at a distance

When live online lessons came up, set-up talk centred on what the teacher could see and hear: hands, posture, feet on the pedals, and mistakes.

4. From feeling to tasks

When learners expressed frustration, boredom, or overwhelm, replies rarely stayed with the feeling. They first framed it as normal, then turned it into a task—How to practice or what to do about the teacher.

Conclusion

- Online piano learners struggled most with choosing: what to use, from whom to learn, and whether online learning could work at all. The problem was not a lack of resources but a lack of criteria to judge them.
- The community responded mainly by pointing to resources and sharing first-hand experience. Much of the advice described options rather than telling learners what to do next.
- Resource recommendations were given regardless of the difficulty type. Only a few difficulties drew matching help: set-up problems received set-up advice, and feelings were addressed with tasks.
- The LLM screened the data much like the researcher with a high degree of similarity. Disagreements arose when the screening criteria required interpretation.



UNIVERSITY of
SOUTH FLORIDA